

LONG TONE BALLADS

FROM DIGGING DEEPER VIDEO #164

Two points of departure here. #1 is that we ALL need to work on our tone, whether we play the sax, or the guitar, or the piano, or the drums. Our TONE is everything, and just pushing the key on a piano isn't the end of the story. Instruments aren't machines that we learn to operate to spec. They are, ideally, extensions of our personalities.

Point #2. When our heroes play the melody to a ballad, it's not so much about WHAT they are playing. We've all heard that tune before. It's about HOW they are playing the tune. Those hundred little subtleties that make them sound like themselves and no one else. What is YOUR approach? Let's get to work figuring it out.

Developing our Tone should be something each of us does every day. Like, EVERY day. There are many exercises on each instrument out there to facilitate this, and most of those are very good and should be worked on. They are also generally very dry, and pretty unmusical. Make a commitment to make MUSIC with your Tone exercises. Play ballads, with intention, out of time. Listen to yourself. Make this a dynamic exercise.

#1 - Body and Soul



A SHORT LIST OF DEVICES, ELEMENTS & CONCERNS

- Tone (this is all you. the depth of your sound, based almost entirely on technique)
- Volume (which effects emotional content and the timbre of your instrument)
- Dynamics (not your overall volume, but how notes sound relative to each other)
- Tapering (the release of the note)
- Rhythm (rhythmic embellishment, subdivisions, swing, straight, over the time, etc)
- Style (Vibrato, glissandos, bends, scoops, grace notes, etc)
- Melodic Embellishments (adding notes, repeating notes, fills, etc)